circles

The internet's reading room.

Design System

Version 1.0 — Figma-Ready Reference

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Product	**circles**
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01 — Color Tokens & Palette

Color Tokens & Palette

All colors are defined as design tokens. Use token names in Figma variables — never hardcode hex values in components.

Primary Tokens

circles Blue
#7DBCFF
--color-brand

Accent Blue
#4F9EE8
--color-accent

Navy
#1E3A5F
--color-navy

Dark
#0F172A
--color-dark

Secondary Tokens

Mid Blue
#3B82F6
--color-mid

Muted
#64748B
--color-muted

Border
#BAD8FF
--color-border

Row Alt
#F0F7FF
--color-row-alt

Light BG
#EFF7FF
--color-light-bg

White
#FFFFFF
--color-white

Semantic Tokens

Success
#059669
--color-success

Error
#DC2626
--color-error

Warning
#F59E0B
--color-warning

Info
#7DBCFF
--color-info

Token Reference Table

Token	Value	Usage
--color-brand	#7DBCFF	Primary CTAs, active states, links, focus rings
--color-accent	#4F9EE8	Hover states, secondary actions
--color-navy	#1E3A5F	Table headers, dark surfaces
--color-dark	#0F172A	Body text, headings (light mode)
--color-muted	#64748B	Captions, placeholders, metadata
--color-border	#BAD8FF	Dividers, card & input borders
--color-light-bg	#EFF7FF	Page backgrounds, card fills
--color-success	#059669	Confirmations, Plant Roots indicator
--color-error	#DC2626	Errors, block states, report flags

01 — Color Tokens & Palette

Opacity Scale & Glow System

Use alpha variants of --color-brand for overlays, ambient cues, and glow effects. Never use solid brand color as a background fill.

circles Blue — Alpha Scale

100%	80%	60%	40%	20%	10%	5%
/FF	/CC	/99	/66	/33	/1A	/0D

Ambient Glow — The Core UI Metaphor

The avatar glow signals live co-presence without interrupting reading. It uses a radial gradient of --color-brand at diminishing alphas. This is the heart of circ

Gradient Tokens

	--gradient-brand	#7DBCFF → #4F9EE8	Buttons, primary CTAs
	--gradient-dark	#0F172A → #1E3A5F	Dark cards, cover backgrounds
	--gradient-glow	#7DBCFF20 → transparent	Ambient presence rings
	--gradient-surface	#EFF7FF → #FFFFFF	Card backgrounds, feed wall depth

02 — Typography Scale

Typography Scale

circles uses Montserrat for all product UI. CausalSyntax company contexts use Raleway. Never mix these in the same element.

Font Pairing

PRODUCT FONT — circles UI

Montserrat

AaBbCcDd 0123456789

Light Regular SemiBold Bold

COMPANY FONT — CausalSyntax

Raleway

AaBbCcDd 0123456789

Regular SemiBold Bold

Type Scale — Montserrat (Product)

Style	Font	Size	Token	Usage
Display	Montserrat Light	40px	--text-display	Hero, splash screens only
H1	Montserrat Bold	28px	--text-h1	Page titles, section headers
H2	Montserrat Bold	20px	--text-h2	Sub-section titles
H3	Montserrat SemiBold	15px	--text-h3	Card titles, group labels
Body Lg	Montserrat Regular	13px	--text-body-lg	Primary reading text
Body	Montserrat Regular	11px	--text-body	Default UI text
Caption	Montserrat Regular	9px	--text-caption	Labels, metadata, timestamps
Micro	Montserrat Bold	8px	--text-micro	Tags, badges, pill labels

Line Height & Letter Spacing

Context	Line Height	Letter Spacing	Notes
Display/H1	120%	-0.5px	Tight — headlines need compression
H2/H3	130%	-0.3px	Slightly relaxed for mid-sizes
Body	160%	0px	Comfortable reading rhythm
Caption/Micro	140%	+0.3px	Tracked for legibility at small sizes

03 — Spacing & Grid System

Spacing & Grid System

Base-4 scale. Every margin, padding, and gap must be a multiple of 4px. Ensures pixel-perfect consistency across iOS, Android, and Web.

Base-4 Spacing Scale

--space-1	4px	Micro gaps, icon padding
--space-2	8px	Tight inline spacing
--space-3	12px	Component internal padding
--space-4	16px	Standard padding unit (base)
--space-5	20px	Card padding
--space-6	24px	Section gaps
--space-8	32px	Large section spacing
--space-10	40px	Page-level margins
--space-12	48px	Hero spacing
--space-16	64px	Max section breathing room

Grid System

Mobile (375px)

4 columns | Gutter: 16px | Margin: 16px

4 col / 16px gutters

Tablet (768px)

8 columns | Gutter: 20px | Margin: 24px

8 col / 20px gutters

Desktop (1440px)

12 columns | Gutter: 24px | Margin: 80px | Max content width: 1280px

Border Radius Tokens

--radius-sm	--radius-md	--radius-lg	--radius-xl	--radius-full
4px · Inputs, tags	8px · Cards, buttons	12px · Modals, panels	20px · Lobby cards	9999px · Pills, avatars

Component Library

All components are built from the token system. Dark mode variants on page 11.

Feed Wall Article Card & Book Card

UX DESIGN

The Quiet Revolution in

Async-First Products

8 min read · Medium

No likes · No comments · No follower count

Article Card | --radius-md | No vanity metrics

BOOK

COVER

Deep Work

Cal Newport

Buy Physical

+ Reading List

Book Card | 3 variants: Free eBook / Paid eBook / Physical

Lobby Card & Persona Card

UX Design & Prototyping

4 Personas active now

"Anyone transitioning from Figma to code?

Open Note · 2 min ago · Tap to Handshake

Lobby Card | Active count, avatar cluster (with glow), Open Notes

CodeCrafter

Kerala, India · Online

React | Systems Design | Solopreneurship

Handshake →

Persona Card | Shown inside Lobby | Alias, location, tags, Handshake CTA

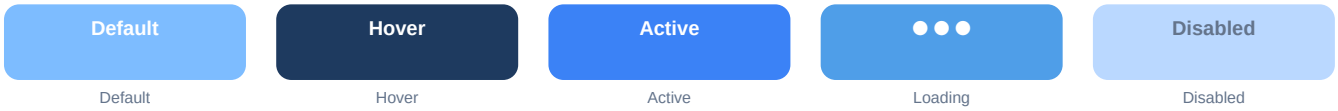
04 — Component Library

Buttons, Inputs & Sponsored Card

Button Variants

primary | secondary | ghost | danger | disabled

Button States — Primary

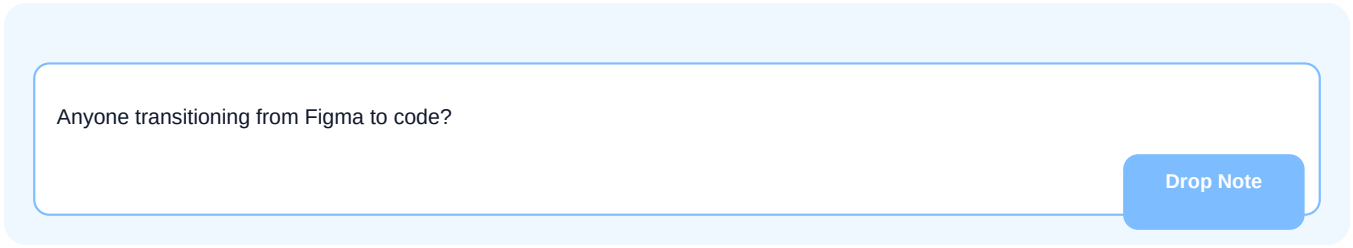


Default | Hover | Active | Loading | Disabled

Input Fields

Default | Focus | Error | Disabled

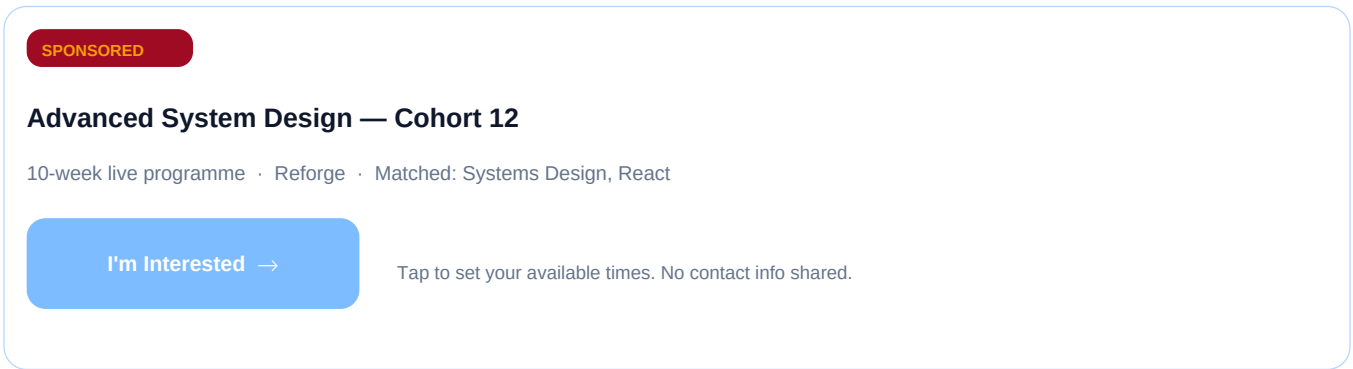
Open Note Input (150 char limit)



Open Note | Max 150 chars | Counter from 100 | CTA activates at 1+ chars

Sponsored Connection Card

Max 1-in-10 Feed Wall items. Always labelled. Never shown in Lobbies, Tables, or Circles.



04 — Component Library

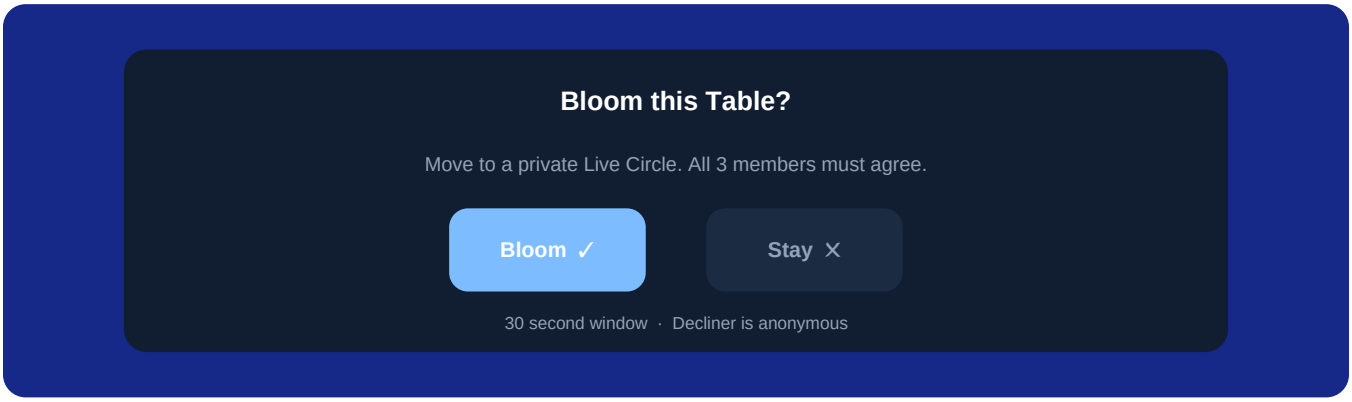
Table, Bloom & Stage Components

Table — Audio Micro-Channel

Two Personas snapped together after a successful Handshake. Private WebRTC audio — others in the Lobby cannot hear.

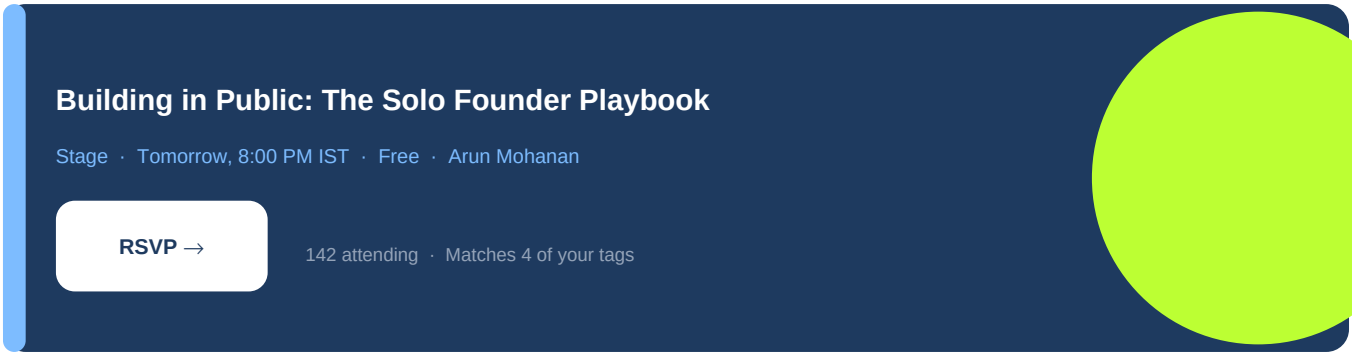
Table | Isolated WebRTC audio | Avatars snap | Others cannot hear

Bloom Consent Modal



Bloom modal | Unanimous consent | 30s timeout | Decliner identity hidden

Stage Banner Card (Feed Wall)



Stage card | Navy bg distinguishes from content | Appears up to 7 days before event

05 — Motion & Animation

Motion & Animation Principles

Motion in circles must feel ambient, never urgent. Every animation reinforces calm presence — it does not demand attention.

Core Motion Principles

Ambient

Motion is always peripheral, never central. The glow pulses in the background. The user keeps reading.

Opt-in

No animation triggers a disruptive state change without user intent. Handshake requests appear softly.

Organic

Easing curves mimic real physics — ease-out for entrances, ease-in for exits. No linear transitions.

Reversible

Every animated state can be undone. Bloom can be cancelled. Tables dissolve. Nothing is permanent.

Duration & Easing Tokens

Token	Duration	Easing	Usage
--motion-fast	120ms	ease-out	Micro: button press, tag toggle
--motion-base	200ms	ease-out	Default: card hover, menu open
--motion-enter	300ms	cubic-bezier(.2,.8,.3,1)	Component entrances, modal open
--motion-exit	200ms	ease-in	Component exits, modal close
--motion-ambient	2400ms	ease-in-out	Avatar glow pulse (infinite loop)
--motion-bloom	500ms	cubic-bezier(.4,0,.2,1)	Table to Live Circle transition
--motion-snap	350ms	cubic-bezier(.34,1.56,.64,1)	Avatar snap to Table (spring)

Signature Animations

Ambient Glow Pulse

Avatar ring opacity oscillates 5% to 22% on 2400ms ease-in-out infinite loop. Starts on co-presence detection. Stops when Lobby dissolves.

Avatar Snap

On Handshake: avatars translate toward each other with spring curve (350ms). Scale pulse 1.0 to 1.08 to 1.0 on arrival confirms connection.

Bloom Transition

Table fades out with scale-down (1.0 to 0.92, 200ms ease-in). Live Circle fades in scale-up (0.94 to 1.0, 300ms ease-out). Total: ~500ms.

Feed Card Entrance

Cards stagger in with 40ms delay each. translateY(12px) to 0 with fade. Scroll-triggered — only animate on viewport entry.

06 — Dark Mode Variants

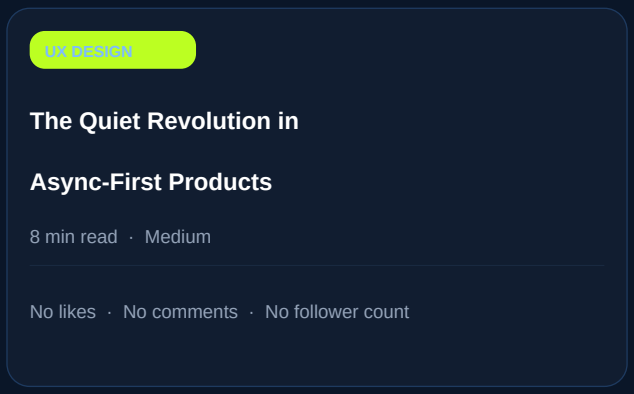
Dark Mode Variants

Dark mode is the primary mode for circles — the reading room lives best at night. All combinations pass WCAG AA contrast.

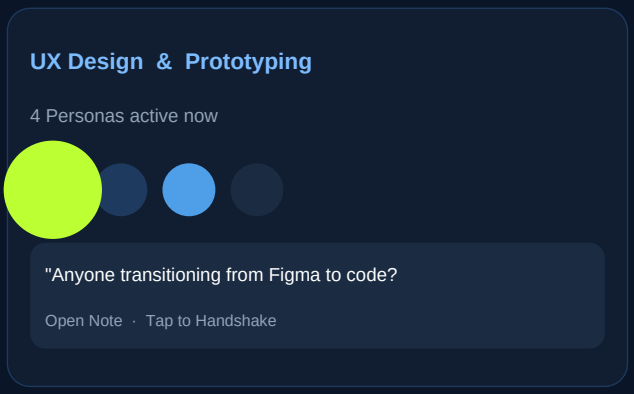
Color Mapping: Light to Dark

Token	Light Value	Dark Value	Usage
--color-bg	#FFFFFF	#0A1628	Page background
--color-surface	#EFF7FF	#111D30	Card, modal surfaces
--color-surface-2	#F0F7FF	#1A2B42	Nested surfaces, rows
--color-text	#0F172A	#F1F5F9	Primary body text
--color-text-muted	#64748B	#94A3B8	Captions, metadata
--color-border	#BAD8FF	#1E3A5F	Dividers, card borders
--color-brand	#7DBCFF	#7DBCFF	Unchanged — brand anchor

Dark Mode Component Previews



Article Card — Dark



Lobby Card — Dark

WCAG Contrast Ratios

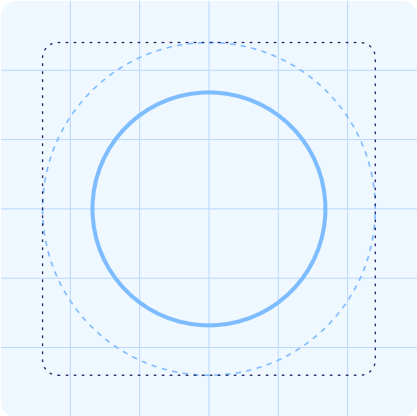
Combination	Values	Ratio	Grade
Body text on dark bg	#F1F5F9 on #0A1628	**16.8:1**	AAA
Muted text on dark bg	#94A3B8 on #0A1628	**7.2:1**	AAA
Brand on dark bg	#7DBCFF on #0A1628	**9.1:1**	AAA
Brand on dark surface	#7DBCFF on #111D30	**7.6:1**	AAA
White on navy header	#FFFFFF on #1E3A5F	**8.3:1**	AAA
Dark on brand button	#0A1628 on #7DBCFF	**9.1:1**	AAA

07 — Iconography Guidelines

Iconography Guidelines

circles uses a custom icon set on a 24x24px grid with 2px stroke. All icons are outlined — never filled — consistent with the circles logo.

Icon Grid & Specifications



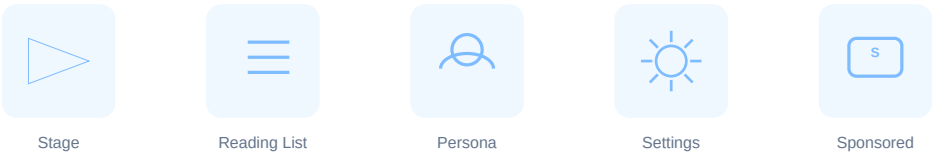
24px grid

2px stroke | 2px safe zone

Grid size	24 × 24 px
Stroke weight	2px — never filled
Corner radius	2px on strokes
Padding	2px safe zone all sides
Export sizes	16, 24, 32, 48px
Format	SVG preferred, PNG@2x
Color token	--color-brand or currentColor
UI sizing	16px micro / 20px default / 24px large
Base library	Lucide Icons + custom overrides

Core Icon Set — circles UI

Drawn as vector stand-ins. Replace with final SVG icons in Figma.



Icon Do's and Don'ts

Don't fill icons	circles uses stroke-only — filled icons break the visual language
Don't go below 16px	Use text labels instead; icons lose meaning at micro sizes
Don't mix styles	All icons must follow the 2px stroke, 24px grid spec
Don't use icons alone	Pair with text labels in onboarding — icons alone lack context